

canal-top solar project, one report suggests that the trial run (held in April earlier this year) produced 15 per cent more power as compared to solar panels deployed over land installations, because the water flowing under the panels in the canal down below helped keep the panels cool. The 1MW leg of the canal-top solar power installation, built by a US company, cost only Rs. 17.5 crores. It's projected to generate and provide 1.6 million units of power annually and at the same time reduce evaporation of 9 million litres of water flowing underneath. What better way to create clean, sustainable energy and eliminate the dependence on coal?

Earlier this year, Gujarat also switched on its solar park, the largest array of photovoltaic cells deployed anywhere in the world, which generates 600 MW of clean energy annually -- generating the same amount of energy conventionally would've required 7.5 lakh tonnes of coal and several hundred crores of capital. Clearly, Gujarat has set an example for the other states of India, showing the nation a way to successfully deploy and harvest solar energy in new ways.

Sustainable Technologies and Environmental Projects

Based in Mumbai, STEPS or Sustainable Technologies and Environmental Projects is an effort to find innovative, greener solutions to tackle India and the world's energy problems. In their own words, waste is energy. As early as January this year, the group announced its intentions to launch a plant that converts plastic waste into a lighter form of diesel. The company has won the Lockheed Martin Innovations Award three times for succeeding to convert algae into diesel.

Diesel extracted through this process can be used in generators, and also refined to petrol and kerosene stage. Reports claim that the stuff can also be purified for use as aviation turbine fuel. STEPS' technology is already at work in a pilot project sanctioned by Mumbai city's municipal corporation. According to a report, the company is considering several joint ventures in this field in countries like Netherlands, Germany, Spain and the US.

Though not exactly green in the conventional sense, it's still an excellent example of salvaging industrial and domestic waste for our energy needs.

IBM GreenTech Initiative

Among the corporates, an IT brand as old as the industry itself is leading the charge in finding cleaner, greener energy alternatives. And when you think of green initiatives, powering data centers through solar arrays isn't